

Dallas Center-Grimes Community School District

Board Report from Madison Melchert, Activities Director

Date: March 2026

Winter Activities

As we close the chapter on an incredible winter season, I want to thank our students, coaches, directors, families, and community members for the passion and support shown over the past few months. From state tournament appearances and record-setting fine arts achievements to championships and postseason runs, our Mustangs have represented DCG with pride and excellence.

At the same time, there is great excitement building as we transition into spring activities. New seasons bring new opportunities, fresh goals, and continued growth for our students. We look forward to seeing our spring athletes and performers take the stage, field, and track as we carry this positive momentum forward.

- **Boys Basketball** concluded their season in the Substate Semifinal at Johnston. While they fell short of advancing to the substate final, the team finished with a strong 13–9 record and competed well throughout the year. Johnston would go on to advance to the state championship game before falling to Cedar Falls. Congratulations to Coach Rankin and the entire basketball program on a competitive and successful season.
- **Girls Basketball** delivered a historic season that captured attention well beyond Iowa. Their semifinal victory over Norwalk, highlighted by Ava Smid's incredible performance, drew national media attention and showcased the resilience and belief that define DCG athletics. While the team fell just short in the state championship game against Carlisle by two points, the impact of this group extends far beyond a final score. Their perseverance, teamwork, and belief demonstrated to young Mustangs, and viewers across the country, that anything is possible with commitment and heart. Congratulations to Coach Jones and his staff on a remarkable season. A special thank you to AJ Ellingson for his support and organization of media coverage during this busy time.
- **Show Choir and Jazz Choir** concluded their successful season by hosting the Take Two competition on March 7. The event was a tremendous success thanks to the work of Friends of the Fine Arts, Mrs. Davenport, Eric Mohlis, and Rebecca Cassel, along with the many volunteers who helped make the day run smoothly. The event coincided with the Girls State Basketball Championship game, and the collaboration between our high school administration, activities staff, and Greg Carenza ensured both events were successfully supported. It was a great example of teamwork and community pride.
- **Individual Speech** wrapped up another exceptional season. At the state contest, DCG qualified 40 total entries for the state contest (27 varsity and 13 freshman entries). Of the 35 performances that competed at State, 28 received Division I ratings and 7 received

Division II ratings. These results reflect the dedication and preparation our students bring to their craft.

- **Jazz Band** continued its tradition of excellence with Jazz 1 earning second place at the Southeast Polk Jazz Festival. In addition, the trombone section was recognized as the Outstanding Section in their class. Congratulations to our musicians and directors on a fantastic performance.
- **Esports** DCG's Overwatch 2 Esports team completed a perfect 7–0 regular season to earn the #2 seed at the Iowa High School Esports Association Winter Showdown State Championship. The Mustangs swept ADM and Marshalltown 3–0 to reach the finals before defeating Williamsburg 3–1 to secure their second consecutive Class 2A state championship. Congratulations to our Esports team on an impressive back-to-back title.

Culture & Identity

This winter season showcased the collaborative and passionate culture that continues to grow within DCG Activities. The success of our Girls Basketball program brought national attention to our school community, highlighting the belief and perseverance that define our student-athletes. At the same time, our ability to successfully host the Take Two Show Choir event on the same day as the Girls State Championship game demonstrated the incredible teamwork and support that exists among our staff, volunteers, and community members.

Looking ahead, we are already beginning the process of building next year's basketball schedules. With the possibility of moving into Class 5A for girls basketball, we are taking a thoughtful and innovative approach to scheduling by evaluating opponents and opportunities that will best prepare our program to compete at the next level.

As we transition to spring, one of the most community-driven events of the year is also approaching. Our track and field meets require a significant number of volunteers, and they consistently highlight the supportive nature of our DCG community. These events are a wonderful opportunity to showcase the pride and involvement that make DCG a special place for our students.

Operations & Finances

The Activities Department continues to work closely with Sean Shatava and Travis Donahue as we advance several facility and operational improvements across campus.

We are nearing a finalized plan for the baseball batting cage project, which will serve as the first phase of a broader facility improvement plan. Future phases will include updates to the backstop, dugouts, and fencing to continue elevating the baseball facility.

In addition, we recently acquired three sets of 10x10 bleachers from the City of Grimes. With the help of our operations staff, these have been moved to campus and will be utilized this spring at the track and field throws venue. In the fall, these bleachers will be relocated to the football

stadium to create a dedicated seating area for our marching band, providing them with their own space while also opening additional seating in the main grandstand.

We are also excited to partner with the DCG Booster Club, Technology, Communications, and Operations on the installation of a new video board at the stadium. The Booster Club has committed \$200,000 toward the project and will support it through seasonal sponsorship opportunities. As we continue discussions with OPN regarding long-term facility planning, the video board will be relocated to the north end of the stadium in anticipation of potential future development to the south.

Additionally, we continue to refine and streamline the facility rental process to improve clarity and efficiency for both internal and community users alongside our business and operational staff. Ongoing collaboration with OPN and district leadership remains focused on thoughtful planning that supports both current needs and long-term growth.

Personal Highlight

One of my personal highlights this month has been watching our fine arts students balance an incredible number of commitments. Many of these students are involved in multiple programs simultaneously; show choir, jazz choir, jazz band, large group speech, individual speech, theater productions, and more. Their ability to manage demanding schedules while continuing to perform at such a high level is truly impressive. Their dedication, passion, and creativity continue to make DCG's fine arts programs something very special.

Looking Ahead

Spring activities are already underway, and excitement continues to build across campus. Boys and Girls Soccer, Boys and Girls Track and Field, Girls Golf, and Boys Tennis are beginning their seasons, while play rehearsals are well underway as our theater students prepare for their upcoming performances.

With warmer weather on the horizon and strong participation across programs, we look forward to another season of growth, competition, and opportunity for our students. If the winter season is any indication, there is much to be excited about as we continue building on an incredible year at DCG.

Madison Melchert

Activities Director

Dallas Center–Grimes High School